The `form_authenticity_token` generates a valid authentication token. That's useful in places where Rails does not add it automatically, like in custom Ajax calls.
The Security Guide has more about this and a lot of other security-related issues that you should be aware of when developing a web application.

10 The Request and Response Objects

In every controller there are two accessor methods pointing to the request and the response objects associated with the request cycle that is currently in execution. The `request` method contains an instance of `AbstractRequest` and the `response` method returns a response object representing what is going to be sent back to the client.

10.1 The `request` Object

The request object contains a lot of useful information about the request coming in from the client. To get a full list of the available methods, refer to the API documentation. Among the properties that you can access on this object are:

Property of `request`	Purpose
host	The hostname used for this request.
domain(n=2)	The hostname's first `n` segments, starting from the right (the TLD).
format	The content type requested by the client.
method	The HTTP method used for the request.
get?, post?, patch?, put?, delete?, head?	Returns true if the HTTP method is GET/POST/PATCH/PUT/DELETE/HEAD.
headers	Returns a hash containing the headers associated with the request.
port	The port number (integer) used for the request.
protocol	Returns a string containing the protocol used plus "://", for example "http://".
query_string	The query string part of the URL, i.e., everything after "?".
remote_ip	The IP address of the client.
url	The entire URL used for the request.

10.1.1 `path_parameters`, `query_parameters`, and `request_parameters`

Rails collects all of the parameters sent along with the request in the `params` hash, whether they are sent as part of the query string or the post body. The request object has three accessors that give you access to these parameters depending on where they came from. The `query_parameters` hash contains parameters that were sent as part of the query string while the `request_parameters` hash contains parameters sent as part of the post body. The `path_parameters` hash contains parameters that were recognized by the routing as being part of the path leading to this particular controller and action.